has won 12 out of the 20 seats we fought polling 15% of votes in Nagaland'[104]

Rapidly shifting local alliances, irrespective of ideological affinity, are not unusual in the Northeast. Even the Congress and the BJP entered into a historic local alliance in the Chakma Autonomous Development Council (CADC), one of the forums under the Sixth Schedule of the Constitution that grants special safeguards to tribal areas. It lasted for a year before unravelling.[105] The BJP had always had alliances in the Northeast. The point is that, once it was firmly in power in Delhi and looked like it was making a serious bid in the Northeast, its value for prospective allies and defectors began rising. All of this took a lot of deft manoeuvring by the BJP's coalition architects like Himanta Biswa Sarma and Ram Madhav—a reflection also of how deeply invested the BJP was in the region from 2014.

Strategy 3: Narratives of Development and the Importance of the Centre in the Northeast

The promise of development and greater efficiency has been a key BJP plank in the Northeast. As one way of testing this, we decided to look at independent satellite data to see how the region had changed under the UPA and NDA governments. For several years now, NASA satellites have been taking publicly available pictures across India every month. Since these images are available over several years, they allow us to observe change visually. My research colleague Rishabh Srivastava extracted NASA VIIRS images for India stretching over a fourteen-year period (2004–2018) to measure nightlights in the Northeast. Nightlights are a good proxy measure to check the progress of electricity connectivity as well increasing economic activity. Srivastava collected over 150 GB of data, wrote a software programme to empirically measure the change in nightlights visible in monthly satellite photos, and then we overlaid them on a parliamentary constituency map of India. In the north-eastern states, the changes were remarkable.

The satellite images showed that nightlights increased across the region: